The Lantern Forest

A short fantasy story for testing Folio

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The Silver Gate

Mira lived at the edge of a forest where the trees glowed after sunset. Each leaf held a tiny light, and the branches whispered in a language only the village elders understood. One evening a silver gate appeared between two ancient oak trees. Beyond it, a small dragon waited beside a lantern. The dragon spoke her name, though they had never met. It said that the forest was losing its magic, and that only a human who could hear the trees could help.

A Dragon Named Ember

The dragon was called Ember. Its scales shone like copper in the warm lantern light. Ember was no larger than a dog, but it could fly above the tallest trees. Mira followed it through the silver gate. The path beneath her feet changed into soft blue moss. Flowers opened as she walked past them, and tiny winged creatures peered out from behind the leaves. Ember explained that a spell had hidden the Heart of the Forest. Without it, the magical lights would slowly fade.

The Whispering River

They reached a river that flowed upward over a hill. Mira had never seen water travel that way. Ember said the river belonged to an old wizard who had changed its course with a song. A stone bridge stood above the water, but it vanished whenever Mira tried to cross. She listened carefully to the trees beside the bank. Their whisper was a riddle about kindness. When she shared her bread with a hungry forest sprite, the bridge became solid beneath her feet.

The Keeper of Dreams

On the far side of the river, a tower rose from the roots of an enormous tree. Inside it lived the Keeper of Dreams. Her cloak was sewn from fallen stars, and her eyes reflected every color of the dawn. She told Mira that magic could not be stolen forever. It returned wherever people chose courage over fear. The Keeper gave her a small crystal. It would glow near the missing Heart, but only if Mira told the truth when the shadows asked her a question.

A Question in the Dark

At the entrance to a dark cave, shadows gathered around the lantern. They asked Mira whether she was afraid. She wanted to say no, because heroes in her favorite stories never seemed frightened. Instead she admitted that she was afraid of the dark and of failing the forest. The crystal began to glow. Ember smiled and said that courage meant doing something worthwhile even when it was difficult. The shadows moved aside, revealing a narrow path into the mountain.

The Heart Returns

Deep in the mountain, Mira found the Heart of the Forest floating inside a glass sphere. She touched the sphere with the crystal, and it opened like a flower. Green light filled the cave. Far above them, the magical trees began to sing. Ember carried the Heart back through the silver gate. By morning every leaf in the forest was shining again. Mira returned home knowing that a small act of honesty could change a whole world. Each evening after that, a little copper dragon visited her window.